CHARRED EGGPLANT AND RICOTTA FILLING

INGREDIENTS

1.6 to 1.8 kg	Japanese eggplants, 10
174 g	Ricotta
5.5 g	Salt

METHOD

1. Heat a grill to medium, or heat the broiler with an oven rack set as close to the element as it goes.
2. Lay the eggplants over the grill, or set them under the broiler. Under the broiler they want a broiler pan or a wire rack in a sheet pan so air moves all around them.
3. Turn and flip them every 5 to 10 minutes until the skins are charred all over and the centers are collapsing soft, 30 to 45 minutes.
4. Leave them at room temperature until they are cool enough to touch.
5. Split each one open and scrape the flesh out with a spoon. It should come away from the skin without a fight. Discard the skins.
6. Line a chinois with cheesecloth, or stand a fine-mesh strainer over a bowl. Pile the flesh in, weigh it down with a plate and refrigerate 2 to 24 hours so the excess liquid seeps out.
7. Puree the drained flesh in a food processor until smooth, stopping once or twice to scrape the sides down.
8. Pass the ricotta through a tamis or a fine-mesh strainer into a bowl.
9. Fold the eggplant into the ricotta until fully integrated, then mix the salt through. Taste and add more. It wants to taste properly seasoned.
10. Cover and refrigerate until you are ready to pipe.

NOTES

The weighted drain is the step that decides whether this works. Two hours minimum, up to 24, or the filling stays watery and loose.
Char the eggplants right through to collapse. Undercooked flesh will not scrape cleanly off the skin and the smoke never gets into it.
The ricotta goes through a tamis before it meets the eggplant. That is what keeps the finished filling smooth.
1.6 to 1.8 kg of raw eggplant reduces to enough filling for 80 to 100 pieces once drained.

DATE ____ / ____ / ____ RATING ____ / 5 OVEN ADJ _____

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